explaining our position. We are not afraid of punishment. But we do not want that we should be wrongly understood'.[4]

What was it that they did not want misunderstood? The explanation is startling. The statement went on, 'According to us, our country is passing through a delicate phase. We saw the coming catastrophe and thought it proper to give a timely warning with a loud voice, and we gave the warning in the manner we thought proper.'[5] It is clear from this that far from being purveyors of mindless violence, the actions of Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt arose from deep political and philosophical convictions. They were masters of strategic defiance. Then came the reference to 'revolution'. With meticulous care and leaving no room for any doubt, they adumbrated how '[i]n our Statement we explained in detail what we mean by "Long Live Revolution"' and that this 'formed the crux of our ideas'. Aggrieved, they pointed out how '[t]hat portion was removed from our statement'. This meant that 'a wrong meaning is attributed to the word revolution' but '[t]hat is not our understanding', because '[b]ombs and pistols do not make a revolution' but rather that '[t]he sword of revolution is sharpened on the whetting-stone of ideas'. They continued, 'This is what we wanted to emphasise. By revolution we mean the end of the miseries of capitalist wars. It was not proper to pronounce judgment without understanding our aims and objects and the process of achieving them. To associate wrong ideas with our names is out and out injustice.'[6]

If the sessions court statement of 6 June 1929 was important, then the high court statement of 12 June 1929 was only marginally less so. Both emphasized that when Bhagat Singh and his colleagues in the HSRA spoke of 'revolution', it was not a revolution of bombs and pistols, but a revolution of ideas. It is significant, however, that this portion was removed from their statement. It was not by accident. What these young men were up against was a state system of unmatched coercion and brutality that was intent on treating them as murderers, fanatics and lunatics. Such refined distinctions were lost on those now judging them as were such sophisticated motives. Small wonder then that the justices would have none of it. They ruled 'motive' to be irrelevant to the sentence even though this was not